

service, we use technologies like RabbitMQ (Rabbit Message Queue) fairly efficiently to push almost 4-5 million events a day into Google BigQuery across all the products we have. We then use this data to analyse how the inventory is moving, and so on.” The company employs around 500 people across the country. Needless to say, its employees work on Linux-based machines. Gidugu says, “We have a strong engineering team of over 60 employees, apart from those dealing with operations. We build all our products in-house. We manage the cloud on our own, as well as the development, deployment and even scaling. All our machines are typically Linux-based. Even within the company, we largely resort to Linux deployment. All the call centre PCs and the laptops that most of our developers use, are Linux-based.” Gidugu finds open source technology a boon for developers. He claims, “One thing that I have found is that as an engineer, my ability to understand a product is significantly enhanced when I look at the source code. With the source code within access, I know what is happening to the software, which is a great thing for any organisation that wants to do things its own way.”

But, open source requires a meticulous approach

The world knows that deploying open source technology is not child's play. In Gidugu's own words, “Personally, I think it is like a double-edged sword. It is about what you make out of it. As long as an organisation has a reasonably smart engineering team and its members can accurately identify the problems that need to be solved, open source technology can work for them. It becomes a question of evaluation. No technology is perfect. If you want to buy a licensed product, you need to wait for the service pack, and if you buy open source technology, of course you have to do a lot of work on your own. But open source technology allows you to have control over how you want to use the product. I don't think there is any one golden rule on how to use open source technology. Any organisation should use it depending upon their needs. We look at the problems that we want to solve and the capabilities that we need. As long as open source technology can solve a problem with some amount



of engineering effort, it's the best choice. At the end of the day, my job is to find optimal engineering solutions to business problems. For example, on the database side, we use MySQL. The databases for all our products are based on pure MySQL deployments.” Companies remain undecided about deploying open source technology in their set-ups largely because they face a shortage of appropriate talent. redBus seems to be an exception. When asked about this, Gidugu says, “We do get the right kind of talent that we require. We are not running a pure services company and we are trying to stay ahead of the industry in terms of the technology curve as well. So what we do is, look for smart engineers. Typically, that means people who are able to work across technologies and have a general knowledge of the complex engineering that is needed. Even otherwise, we have never faced a situation in which we could not hire people. There is enough talent available. You just need to pick and choose the best. Another thing people should keep in mind is the licensing aspects of OSS. That is something we are very careful about when we pick a particular open source technology. It depends on whether you want to use the technology for a commercial or non-commercial use. It is not easy to understand all the licensing issues around the open source model. OSS licensing has been simplified to a certain extent in recent times but I would say that one still needs to pay attention to this before you make an OSS choice.” 

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